

Twenty years ago we could assume that the brightest students from the best high schools knew *something*. We can't assume that anymore. We test all entering students, regardless of where they went to high school or how well they did, for basic reading and math skills. Based on the test results, we revise our curriculum to meet the needs of the less-advanced students. Happily, the kids are so bright and eager to learn that they can pick up what they need very quickly."

COLLEGE

My scholar friend who says "the education you get is the life you lead" also says, with respect to higher education, "It's not where you start, it's where you end up that counts." Small southern towns may provide a relaxed way of life that children love. An international school in Brazil may give a child memories he'll cherish all his life. But what about college? How does Johnny get into Cornell with a high-school diploma from rural Georgia rather than Grosse Pointe? How does Suzie get into Cal Tech when her high school in Kentucky doesn't even offer calculus?

Let's look a little closer at your children's college career. First, start with the premise that there's no such thing as a good college. "Good for what?" is the question. Colleges come in all sizes, in all parts of the country, and with all kinds of standards. You may want Suzie to go to Yale and later become a lawyer. But Suzie may want to go to Arizona State and party, thank you. You may want Johnny to major in biology and be a doctor. But Johnny may want to major in economics, take an extra year to study chemistry, and then go to medical school. Doing it that way will take a year longer, and Johnny may have a harder time getting into medical school. But if that's the way Johnny wants to do it, you're probably foolish to try to talk him out of it.

Second, recognize that Johnny will most likely go to a public university. On a budget of \$4,000 a year you won't